

Task 7 :Identify and Remove Suspicious Browser Extensions

Objective

The objective of this task was to:

1. Inspect the installed browser extensions/add-ons.
2. Identify any extensions that may be suspicious, unnecessary, or potentially harmful.
3. Remove or disable such extensions.
4. Understand how browser permissions, reviews, and developer details help in assessing the risk level of an extension.

2. Tools Used

- Web Browser: Google Chrome
- Operating System: Windows 10
- Internet Connection: For checking reviews, permissions, and developer information of extensions.

3. Methodology

3.1 Opening Extension

1. Launched the browser.
2. Navigated to the extensions page:

For Chrome: Menu (⋮) → More Tools → Extensions

For Firefox: Menu (≡) → Add-ons and themes → Extensions

3.2 Listing and Reviewing Installed Extensions

1. Noted down all currently installed extensions.
2. For each extension, I checked:
 - Description and purpose
 - Requested permissions (e.g., “Read and change all your data on the websites you visit”)
 - Number of users and ratings
 - Developer/publisher name and website
 - Last update date
 - User reviews and any security-related complaints

3.3 Identifying Suspicious or Unnecessary Extensions

- Extensions were marked as suspicious or unnecessary if they had one or more of the following characteristics:
- Vague or misleading description
- Excessive permissions not required for its stated purpose
- Very low rating or many negative reviews mentioning malware/adware
- Unknown or untrusted developer
- Not used by me for a long time

3.4 Removing / Disabling Extensions

1. For each suspicious or unused extension, I clicked Remove (or Disable in Firefox).
2. Confirmed removal when prompted by the browser.

3.5 Post-Removal Checks

1. Restarted the browser.
2. Verified that:
 - Removed extensions were no longer listed.
 - Browser performance (startup time, page loading) improved or remained stable.
 - No unexpected pop-ups, redirects, or ads appeared.

4. Observations and Findings

S. No.	Extension Name	Type (Useful / Suspicious / Unused)	Key Permissions Requested	Remarks
1.	Adblock / uBlock Origin	Useful	Access to website data for blocking ad	Trusted, well-known extension. Used regularly for work.
2.	Screenshot Tool	Useful	Capture screen, access tabs	
3.	XYZ Deals Finder	Suspicious	Read & change al	Used regularly for work. Untrusted, high-risk permissions, poor reviews.
4.	Unknown PDF Converter	Unused / Suspicious	Access to all websites, manage downloads	Not used recently. Vague description.

General Observations

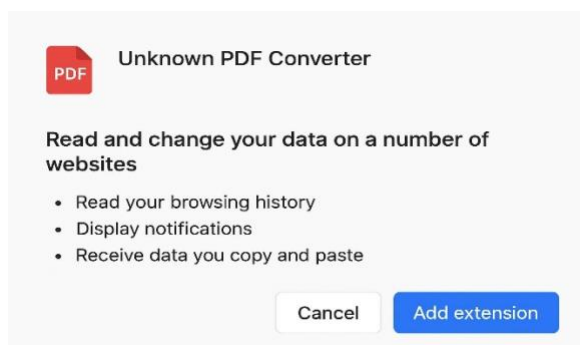
- A few extensions requested broad permissions such as “Read and change all your data on all websites”, which can be risky if the extension is not from a trusted developer.
- Removing unused extensions reduced clutter and potential attack surface.
- After removal of suspicious extensions, the browser felt slightly faster and there were fewer random pop-ups/ads (if you noticed any, mention it here).

5. Screenshots

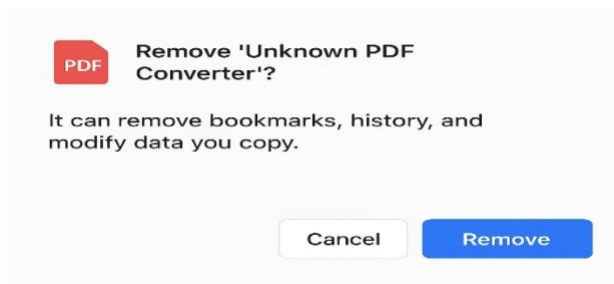
1. Full list of installed extensions before cleanup.



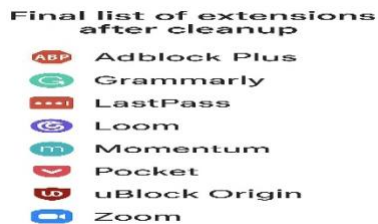
2. Example of permissions page/details for a suspicious extension.



3. Confirmation dialog while removing an extension.



4. Final list of extensions after cleanup.



6. Outcome

Through this task, I:

- Gained awareness of how browser extensions can affect privacy, security, and performance.
- Learned to carefully analyze permissions, developer reputation, and user reviews before trusting an extension.
- Understood the importance of regularly auditing installed extensions and removing anything that is unnecessary or suspicious.
- Observed how removing such extensions can contribute to a safer and smoother browsing experience.

8. Conclusion

The task successfully demonstrated the importance of regularly auditing browser extensions to reduce security risks. By identifying and removing suspicious or unnecessary extensions, I improved the security posture of my browser and gained practical skills in assessing extension trustworthiness, understanding permissions, and maintaining a safer browsing environment.